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IN THE CM RACE
Senior Congress leaders D.K. Shivakumar,G. Parameshwar and Siddaramaiah at a protest against the BJP in Bengaluru, Mar. 24

(Secular) coalition government in the state, it is crunch time now, with less than a month left for the assembly election due on May 10.

This time as well, as in 2018, political observers reckon it will be a close fight in which a variety of local factors will weigh in, including the shrewd calculations behind the selection of candidates for the state's 224 assembly seats. Therefore, even the BJP waited before revealing its hand—it finalised 189 candidates after marathon meetings only on April 11 by which time the Congress had released two lists of 165 candidates and endured some inevitable backlash from local leaders disappointed at having missed the party ticket. "In some situations, winnability is important," said Shivakumar at a recent press conference. The BJP, likewise, has left some old-timers miffed, by nominating fresh faces in their place. The Congress has so far given tickets to 10 leaders from rival parties, including three former BJP legislators who had quit their posts recently. This outgo from the ruling party, Shivakumar claimed, was a sign of a "wave in favour of the Congress".

THE BJP, LOOKING TO TIE DOWN BOTH SIDDARAMAIAH AND SHIVA KUMAR TO THEIR SEATS, IS FIELDING SENIOR MINISTERS IN VARUNA AND KANAKAPURA

In the 2018 election, the Congress was marginally ahead of the BJP in terms of vote share—38 per cent against the latter's 36.22 per cent—but behind it in the number of seats. It won only 80 seats while the BJP managed 104. The reason for this, explains political commentator Prof. A. Narayana, is that the Congress has a broader base spread across all constituencies, unlike the BJP's relatively smaller footprint at the time. "The BJP had a strategic presence," he says. This time, with BJP heavyweight B.S. Yediyurappa, who was his party's chief ministerial face back then, retiring from the electoral race, the Congress is sensing a chance to woo the Veerashaiva-Lingayats back. Similarly, it reached out to other communities such as the Madigas who had drifted to the BJP in recent elections. It's in this context that the Basavaraj Bommai government's gambit of increasing reservation quota for Dalits and key communities like Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas assumes considerable significance. On